

Smoking Characteristics by Type of Employment

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Smoking habits are examined in a probability sample of 75,827 American men and women. The data was obtained from The 1970 Household Interview Survey conducted by The National Center for Health Statistics. There are pronounced differences in prevalence intensity, kind, cessation of smoking related to type of employment. Occupations tend to be more of a factor in white males, where occupational choice is least encumbered, than in black males or in females. While blacks uniformly smoke with greater prevalence, they are much lighter smokers than whites. Employed women tend to smoke with prevalence approaching males for many occupations. Prevalence of smoking almost uniformly is highest among blue collar occupations and lowest among professionals, managers, and proprietors.

More than 20 years ago Haenszel *et al*¹ found that occupational characteristics are among the environmental, social and cultural factors that influence smoking patterns. Little substantive information has been gathered since then that would be useful in describing the smoking habit by different types of employment. Yet our need to know more about the prevalence of smoking in different occupations and industries strikingly increases as we learn more about occupational antecedents of disease.² The existence of smoking differences among occupations was verified in three recent studies. Dunn *et al*³ reported a greater prevalence of smokers and a heavier smoking rate among 70,000 male California blue collar workers (asbestos workers, cooks, crane operators

and engineers, painters, plumbers, printers, sheet metal workers, and welders) than among other California males used as controls. Higgins⁴ found that smoking patterns differ considerably depending on whether or not individuals were employed and depending on whether or not the employment was white collar, blue collar, or agricultural. Friedman *et al*⁵ found that smokers more often reported occupational exposures to a variety of fumes, sprays, dust, extreme heat and loud noises than did nonsmokers.

It is also known that smoking habits differ by sex and race as well as by a variety of physical and cultural characteristics. In so far as occupational characteristics also differ by sexual and racial categories, a complex relationship may exist between smoking habits and occupation, sex and race of which not much appears to be known presently.

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An opportunity arose to obtain detailed data of the distribution of smoking habits by occupation, industry, sex and race from the Health Interview Survey (HIS) of 1970.⁶ The HIS collects information on a continuing nation-wide sample of households as part of the ongoing activity of the National Center for Health Statistics (NCHS). In 1970, HIS utilized a questionnaire which requested, among others, information on the nature of an employed individual's occupation and the industry in which he was employed as well as a detailed description of smoking habits. The survey is conducted by interviewing a sample of households each week which have been selected from the civilian noninstitutionalized U.S. population, using a sophisticated stratified probability sampling technique, in such a way that each weekly sample of households is representative of the target population and that weekly samples are additive over time. (The detailed description of the design of the survey and general qualifications of the data obtained from the survey may be found in reference 7.)

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